HIGHER SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS
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THE GOVERNMENT OF RUSSIAN FEDERATION
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«HIGHER SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS»

FACULTY OF WORLD ECONOMY AND WORLD POLITICS
International Program 'International Relations and Global Studies'

Thesis Paper
On the topic:

«Features of the United Nations Communication Strategy for Sustainable Development Goals (2015–2024) »

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NATIONAL RESEARCH UNIVERSITY

MOSCOW 2025

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Introduction

Relevance

With 17 sustainable development goals, the UN unveiled a new, ambitious agenda in September 2015. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are the forerunners of the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), which were announced in September 2000 as part of the United Nations Millennium Declaration. Under the "Transforming Our World: The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development" framework, the United Nations approved the Sustainable Development Goals, also known as the Global Goals, in 2015 with the aim of promoting equality, prosperity, and peace. There are 169 goals in all, spanning the social, economic, and environmental domains.

Around the globe, individuals, organisations, and governments are starting to place an increased value on sustainability. Thus, effective sustainability communication is more crucial than ever. Strategic communication is an integral part of the mentioned above international sustainable agenda. It is an approach which allows to distribute information via various sources as well as ensure that the information is received by the required group. Communicating sustainability is a vital step in achieving the SDG agenda by raising awareness. Understanding the crucial role that communication plays in achieving the 2030 Agenda and the SDGs into practice requires a closer look at the 2030 Agenda for SD. Even while the 2030 Agenda as a whole doesn't specifically address communication or how the UN or its UN Member States should go about spreading the 2030 Agenda and the SDGs, it is nevertheless possible to infer messages of communication. Sustainability communication is a powerful instrument for promoting meaningful change, as Thomas (2023) observes.

In order to effectively promote the SDGs, it is crucial to fully comprehend the advantages of connecting them to local issues and coordinating national and subnational plans with the 2030 Agenda. This is particularly important when policymakers are the intended audience. In contrast, it is also important to make the message of SDGs universal and unified, in order to create an integrated environment. Therefore, communication strategy is crucial for the UN to achieve its 2030 objectives. "Communicating about the SDGs and building awareness is a critical initial and ongoing step in the successful implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development"[1], (European Environmental Bureau, 2020). It also makes it easier to develop the knowledge, decision-making, and action-capabilities that are essential to the delicate collaboration between the stakeholders.

In its landmark resolution 72/279, the General Assembly decided to fundamentally restructure the UN development system to better achieve the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. It focuses on "repositioning of the United Nations development system in the context of the quadrennial comprehensive policy review of operational activities for development[2]". It strives towards a more coordinated strategy. This would entail cooperative advocacy, coordinated communications, and complete accountability and transparency of results. This shows that communication strategy is being altered, and does not stay the same in comparison to the SDGs.

The challenges posed by the United Nations' new agenda test the effectiveness of an international organization's current structure and call for a re-evaluation of communication strategies. Thus, it is of high importance to analyse the evolution of communication strategy of the SDGs and its influence on the

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[1] European Environmental Bureau, . (2020). *Sustainable Development Handbook*. Retrieved from: https://www.sdgwatcheurope.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/7-Communicating-about-the-SDGs.pdf

[2] United Nations General Assembly. (2018, May 31). *Repositioning of the United Nations development system in the context of the quadrennial comprehensive policy review of operational activities for development* (A/RES/72/279). United Nations. https://undocs.org/en/A/RES/72/279

achievements of the objectives set. Tools, methods and transforms have to be thoroughly considered when examining the sustainability communication strategy.

Literature Review

This literature review examines key research and publications related to communication of sustainable development. One of the relevant pieces of literature is called “Communication and awareness raising in the implementation of the 2030 agenda and the SDGs: Activities and challenges” by Mullholland et.al (2017). The literature investigates the United Nations' activities and communication methods used to promote the sustainable development agenda and what challenges the UN faces while implementing them. The article analyses sic specific cases of communication and awareness-raising techniques. The author comes to a conclusion that to effectively reach diverse stakeholders, countries should combine personalized communication with broader awareness-raising efforts, ensuring the SDGs are contextualized at national and subnational levels to make them more relatable and impactful. Moreover, the article by Lim (2022) called “The sustainability pyramid: A hierarchical approach to greater sustainability and the United Nations sustainable development goals with implications for marketing theory, practice, and public policy” analyses the communication strategy of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) agenda, focussing on rethinking methods for marketing and communicating sustainability while suggesting innovative approaches. The article originates from the field of sustainable development studies. The main argument issue of the research is the public's ignorance regarding the threat of unsustainable consumption. Consequently, the author presents a novel approach to conveying sustainability. The author argues that the 2030 agenda is unlikely to be achieved, particularly in Asia and the Pacific, highlighting the detrimental impact of Covid-19 on the attainment of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Concepts

such as sustainable development and communication strategies are widely used and well-defined. The author's qualitative research orientation provides a practical solution to the issue. The author primarily employs the conceptual method, which thoroughly evaluates established concepts and theories before introducing his own theory. The author presents a theory termed “The Sustainability Pyramid,” a model that introduces innovative approaches to sustainability. Marketing efforts should convey messages in a hierarchical order: economic, social, and environmental sustainability. This will modify the marketing message, enhancing the appeal of sustainability to consumers by emphasising the economic benefits of the initiative. The strength of the following article is that it provides a practical solution as well as the novelty of the theory offered. As for the limitations, it has a narrow scope since it focuses mainly on consumers thus contributing solely to SDG 12 and potentially oversimplifying the concept of sustainable development. Moreover, the article “Crisis Communication vs. United Nation Sustainable Development Goals: The 7S Paradigm as Feasible Solution Facilitator” by Looser et.al (2019). The literature looks at the interaction between the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and various industries through a communication perspective. The study proposes the "7S(-stakeholder) Paradigm," which emphasises communication on many levels. The framework provides practical instructions for managing stakeholder communications across the commercial, public, and third sectors, with adaptive decision-tree architectures for diverse conflict scenarios. Another noteworthy piece is the article by Janoušková et al. (2019) named “Sustainable development—A poorly communicated concept by mass media. Another challenge for SDGs?”, which examines the theme of communicating Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) through mass media sources, emphasising the ineffectiveness of these outlets. The articles originate from sustainability and media studies. The primary dilemma presented in the article is that sustainability is inadequately communicated, and the communicative potential of predominantly English-speaking outlets is underutilised. Janoušková et al. (2019) highlights that despite sustainable development being internationally

recognised, it did not become appealing to many. One of the main arguments of the article is that scientists and educators, as well as politicians, play a critical role in the development of appropriate narratives and the provision of dependable information to the media. The author uses a qualitative research orientation to analyse communication strategies. The methodology being used by the authors is the one of content analysis, particularly analysis of published media, mainly newspapers. By analysing content, the authors look into newspaper articles covering sustainability themes in an implicit way and those explicitly linking them to the overarching sustainability concept. The aim of the research is to provide holistic insights on how to better communicate sustainability through mass media sources. One of the main advantages of the following study is that empirical evidence is used to analyse communication strategies of sustainable development, providing insights from mass media over the past ten years. The disadvantages of the article is the fact that content analysis is carried out solely on English speaking media, meaning that research has a limited scope and does not use a full spectrum of global media. The article "The impact of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals on corporate sustainability reporting" by Whittingham et.al (2023) is a good addition to the research. A notable emphasis on the institutional forces influencing sustainability reporting is seen in the literature. Research has looked into how corporate environmental practices are influenced by normative demands. Similar to this, studies have shown that institutional and regional contexts are important factors in influencing how businesses react to sustainability communication. Methodological precedent for examining large-scale corporate communications has been established by research that has used computer-aided text analysis to investigate shifts in corporate sustainability discourse. Therefore, this literature looks at communication of SDGs from a corporate scope. Furthermore, the article under the name "Communication for sustainable development: applications and challenges" by Mefalopulos (2005). The author highlights that sustainable development encompasses three dimensions: environment, rural development, and social issues, with poverty reduction as a

central concern. Fostering empowerment and participation, the two primary pillars of sustainable development, requires effective communication. Mefalopulos highlights that engaging stakeholder in decision-making processes requires participatory communication as opposed to top-down methods. He does point out that participation's promise is undermined by frequent abuse and uneven application. The Participatory Rural Communication Appraisal (PRCA) methodology, which empowers communities by fusing communication strategies with participatory approaches, is also covered in the paper. Mefalopulos comes to the conclusion that in order to improve the efficacy and durability of development programs, communication should be incorporated from the very beginning. Building trust, exchanging knowledge, and making sure that stakeholders' viewpoints are truly taken into account are the ultimate goals of communication for sustainable development. The article “Communicating sustainability: An analysis of the 2017 United Nations sustainable development goals report” by Franson (2018) analyses communication strategy based on content analysis of the UN report, this method will be employed in the following research as well. The scholar analyses the UN's Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) communication strategy to get a better understanding of their contribution to sustainable development. The SDGs, which were first introduced in 2015, provide a refreshed agenda for global development from 2015 to 2030 and are modelled after the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs). This study looks at how the SDGs are presented in the 2017 SDG Report, emphasising important topics including framing analysis, cultural aspects, and knowledge translation. The SDG Report summarises accomplishments and identifies areas that require development, acting as a knowledge translation tool. However, issues including language hurdles, lack of internet connection, and disparities in cultural beliefs restrict its usefulness and accessibility. In order to improve the worldwide adoption of sustainable practices, suggestions are made to improve the communication strategy while guaranteeing inclusion and cultural sensitivity. Another noteworthy piece of literature for the given research is the journal article

"Communication for all and the Sustainable Development Goals" written by McLeod & Marshall (2023). It has 36 studies that examine how different global issues, such as poverty, hunger, health, education, employment, innovation, climate change, urban development, terrestrial and marine ecosystems, justice, and international partnerships, may be addressed by effective communication techniques. In addition to being a basic human right, the collection highlights how important communication is for promoting sustainable development in a variety of fields. The article promotes inclusive and participatory methods that empower communities and stakeholders globally by including communication into the SDGs framework. Another work which would be relevant for the following literature review is named "From Millennium Development Goals to Sustainable Development Goals: Transforming development communication to sustainability communication" by Kannengießer (2023). The scholar explores the move from the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and its implications for development communication. It makes the case that the change from the MDGs to the SDGs represents a basic paradigm shift away from conventional ideas of development and towards frameworks that are more concerned with sustainability. The authors stress that this transformation calls for a reinterpretation of development communication in terms of sustainability communication, which combines the objectives of sustainability with the concepts of social change communication. The paper emphasises the significance of embracing sustainability communication as a specialised discipline within larger communication for social change by looking at the development of these global aims. It implies that the overall goal of advancing sustainable development may be better aligned with communication practices through the use of effective sustainability communication. In the end, the paper promotes a more focused strategy in which communication initiatives are specifically linked to sustainability goals, increasing their applicability and influence. Another chapter from the book "The sustainability communication reader" will be applicable for the research. The chapter "Sustainability Communication as Critical Perspective

in Media and Communication Studies—an Introduction" by Weder at.al (2021). The chapter presents sustainability communication as a crucial, emerging field within media and communication studies. In light of overlapping issues like the COVID-19 epidemic and associated socioeconomic difficulties, it recognises the need of tackling the climate catastrophe. According to the authors, sustainability acts as a moral compass that directs behaviour at the institutional, organisational, community, and individual levels in order to promote a regenerative connection between people and the natural world. The essay also makes a distinction between communication about, about, and for sustainability, highlighting the unique roles that each strategy plays in furthering the conversation about sustainability. It also emphasises how important it is to question the dominant growth-oriented paradigm and promotes more open dialogue regarding de-growth and alternative frameworks. The article's overall goal is to position sustainable communication as a young area with adaptable limits, encouraging more research and development in the field of media and communication studies. To add, the piece of literature which discusses the role of digital technologies "Information and communications technologies for sustainable development goals: state-of-the-art, needs and perspectives" by Wu.et al (2018). The writers look at how ICTs support sustainable development's social, economic, and environmental pillars. The study finds through a thorough literature assessment that the majority of contributions from reputable research communities, such as IEEE and ACM, are primarily technical and lack a more comprehensive social good viewpoint. A major research gap in integrating ICTs into comprehensive sustainability frameworks is highlighted by this limited focus on technology solutions. To effectively use ICTs to achieve the SDGs by 2030, the authors promote increased awareness and creative thinking. In order to fully use ICTs' potential to support sustainable development, they stress the necessity of bridging technological breakthroughs with thorough social and environmental issues, eventually advocating for multidisciplinary collaboration. Furthermore, the book "The Palgrave handbook of international communication and sustainable development" written by Yusha'u

& Servaes (2021) brings insights into the following literature review. According to the handbook, good communication is crucial to the SDGs' successful implementation and should be acknowledged as a key element of the 2030 Agenda. It critically assesses the present SDG framework and schedule while reflecting on issues like the COVID-19 epidemic and highlighting the need for strong communication infrastructures. The chapters seek to enhance the conversation on development communication and suggest crucial policy initiatives through unique SDG analysis and case studies tailored to a particular nation. The given book would come at use as a prime example for the third chapter, which deals with case studies. The article “Sustainable development goals: conceptualization, communication and achievement synergies in a complex network framework” by Bellantuono et al. (2022) examines how the perception of SDGs influences their progress and achievements. The authors build a three-layer multiplex network, with each layer representing a link between the SDGs based on accomplishment indicators, communication patterns, and conceptual commonalities. The analysis finds strategic SDGs that are essential in various settings by looking at centrality within these networks. The substantial relationship between SDG success patterns and their perception and communication, as demonstrated by social network data, is a noteworthy discovery. This implies that public opinion and conversation may either impact or be impacted by the advancement of particular SDGs. The study offers a framework for comprehending the intricate relationships between the SDGs, providing information that may help build decision support tools for creating and carrying out successful sustainability plans. Another article “The role of sustainability in media and communication studies' curricula throughout Europe” by Karmasin & Voci (2021) discusses the pivotal role of media in sustainable development. Article shows that Only 14% of the curriculum incorporates sustainability elements, according to research that examined 1,068 bachelor's and master's degree programs from 28 different nations. Because of this lack of integration, sustainability is still mostly a guiding concept rather than a specific

course offering. The results urge consideration of the social and pedagogical obligations of higher education institutions and draw attention to difficulties in operationalising sustainability within media and communication courses. While some universities do incorporate sustainability, the study finds that these are often done through voluntary rather than required classes. Furthermore, the study indicates that the absence of institutional commitment and a clear operationalisation of sustainability principles impede integration attempts. Finally, the article, "Can social media improve stakeholder engagement and communication of Sustainable Development Goals? A cross-country analysis" by De Luca et.al (2022). It explores how social media, particularly Twitter, influences stakeholder engagement with the United Nations' 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The study uses a dataset of 3,045 tweets from 173 companies in 19 European countries. Posts are categorised by level of participation using the Chi-square Automatic Interaction Detection (CHAID) approach. The findings show that engagement rates are greatly impacted by several tweet attributes, including content type, hashtags, links, word count, industry type, and the firm's nationality. The highest levels of involvement are generated by SDGs pertaining to gender equality, partnerships, climate action, reduced inequality, life on land, life below water, and decreased inequality. This is the first study to evaluate how corporations' communication of particular SDGs affects stakeholder participation on social media. It emphasises how crucial well-crafted messaging is to fostering better stakeholder engagement and communication on sustainability goals.

Primary sources include UN SDG annual reports, official campaign materials, and social media posts, which provide direct data.

Research gap

The following research will fill a research gap by analysing the social media outlets used by the United Nations for communication. Previous studies mostly examined paper-based media, rather than social apps. Such an approach was not

seen in earlier literature, demonstrating its uniqueness and novelty. Social media posts will allow us to track the progress from a direct source (UN).

This methodological innovation tackles not just the current change in institutional communication, but also gives real-time insights into the UN's public engagement techniques, considerably adding to the existing body of knowledge in international communications research.

Research Question

The research question is as follows: "How have the features of the United Nations' communication strategy evolved in the context of the Sustainable Development Goals agenda from 2015 to 2024?".

Hypothesis

The hypothesis will have a two-levelled approach. 1)The hypothesis is that the UN's communication strategy will go through digitalization as a foundational communication medium to enhance global reach and accessibility. 2) The characteristics of communication strategy will change. Shifting towards global awareness and residing knowledge about newly introduced SDGs from 2015 to 2017, 2018 to 2021 was described by increasing reach, engagement and support in the period of a global health crisis and from 2022 up to 2024 UN concentrated on localised issues and overall led a localised approach.

Methodology

As the basis for the IR theory of the following research liberalism will be considered as a foundation. Liberal thought best explains the need for a communication strategy in sustainable development because the core principles of the theory are completely in line with the way the SDGs are promoted globally,

particularly its emphasis on many stakeholders, open information exchange, transparency, and institutional cooperation. The theory's emphasis on absolute gains over relative gains helps us understand why the communication strategy focuses on collective benefits and shared prosperity rather than competitive advantages. Through this theoretical lens, we may better understand how the SDG communication strategy functions as a vehicle for establishing global alliances, developing international consensus, and encouraging cooperation—all of which are crucial for accomplishing the goals of sustainable development. However, while looking at SDGs from idealism some criticise them for being too idealistic. A common criticism of idealism in international relations is that it is a utopian philosophy. The strategy may appear overly optimistic about the capacity of international organizations to coordinate messaging effectively across diverse cultural, political, and economic contexts. However, despite criticism, liberalism's emphasis on international institutions provides a practical mechanism for coordinating global action on complex challenges like sustainable development through institutionalism. According to Keohane and Nye (1977), international institutions play a critical role in promoting cooperation and stability by reducing information asymmetries, fostering transparency, and building trust among states.

As for the methodology of the research, to examine the development of UN communication strategies, the suggested methodology takes a thorough three-sided approach which will employ both qualitative and quantitative methods.

A comprehensive content analysis will be carried out to look at UN digital platforms and communication materials from 2015 to 2024. This will also include analysis of posts posted by the UN on various media platforms and formal, official documents. Examining documents and social media postings, the website will be part of the content analysis process in order to spot trends and changes in communication tactics of SDGs. We shall be able to examine how the UN's language evolves throughout the designated time frame thanks to the study. This will be a mixture of quantitative and qualitative methods, since firstly marker

words will be counted and only then interpreted to trace any specific patterns. The data will be secluded to desk research and collected from open sources such as the UN website and relevant literature. The disadvantage of the method is that not all documents related to this topic will be in full access or the data will be published implicitly, which will make data collection lengthier.

Secondly, case studies will be employed to examine how the UN presents itself in the global environment and what kind of message it transfers. These case studies will investigate how global messaging was adapted to address local needs and cultural sensitivities, analyzing specific examples of regional communication campaigns and their effectiveness. This component will help understand how the UN balanced maintaining consistent global messaging while accommodating local contexts and stakeholder needs. The case studies will include detailed examinations of communication strategies from different time periods and touching various subjects to make the investigation space broader. 3 campaigns from various time periods will be picked to create a wide spectrum of representation. Thirdly, comparative analysis will be carried out to trace similarities and differences between the three campaigns which will allow to tracks the evolution of features on a deeper scale. The drawback of this message is that despite the broad choice of campaigns, some campaigns will be excluded due to the word limit of the research, which will narrow down the knowledge.

The expected outcome will be a comprehensive analysis of UN's evolving features of communication strategies from 2015 to 2024, with particular focus on social media engagement. This research will uniquely contribute to the field by providing real-time features of the UN's sustainability communication strategy.

The time frame is between 2015 and 2024. It starts with 2015 because the SDG agenda was announced during the year, while 2024 is a midpoint of the 2030 agenda, which captures nearly a decade of SDG progress. Also, 2024 is the maximum present time which is available for analysis.

The object of the following research is the United Nations' communication strategy in the sustainable development field. The subject is features and evolution of the communication strategy in the time frame 2015 to 2024.

As for the limitations of the research paper, the information about communication strategies may be concealed, which will make it more difficult to gather data and infer information from publicly published sources. Furthermore, another limitation is the time constraint applied to this research; the deadline should be met under a time framework

The aim of this research is to examine how the features of the United Nations' communication strategy have evolved in the context of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) from 2015 to 2024. The objectives of the research are:

- Conduct historical background analysis
- Identify role of communication in achieving SDGs
- Perform content analysis of UN reports and social media
- Identify key patterns in content analysis using marker words
- Select three UN campaigns and carry out case studies
- Compare case studies of three UN campaigns
- Provide political recommendations based on findings

Structure

The structure of the research will look as follows: it will start with an introduction (relevance, literature review, research question and hypothesis, research gap, methodology, and structure), which is being read now. Overall, the following research will be written in three chapters. The first chapter will discuss the general background of the UN's communication strategy of sustainability. The following topics will be discussed to present and through context of the research: the role of communication in global governance and sustainable development, overview of UN communication strategies prior to 2015 (MDGs agenda), the role

of communication in achieving the 17 SDGs and, finally the evolving role of digital media and technology in UN communication. The second chapter will deal with content analysis. UN digital platforms as well as documents will be analysed, and the evolution of communication methods and features will be identified. In the third chapter, the case studies of 3 different UN campaigns regarding SDG from 3 different time periods will be analysed. Through this process major patterns will be spotted, including both evolution of communication channels and its characteristics. After that, the hypothesis will either be validated or disproved. Other prepositions will be provided in the case of refusal. The conclusion at the end will provide a summary to sum up the study and outline all the main arguments of the research.

Approaching the criteria of my research, the indicators which will be taken into account during the research are relevance, reliability and originality. By emphasising the UN's initiatives to advance the SDGs through many platforms and its effect on stakeholders, relevance is attained. The use of official papers, reports, and analysis of social media of the UN analysis guaranteed reliability. Consistent approach across all years of study is necessary for reliability. The study also places a high value on uniqueness, offering new perspectives on strategic communication changes between 2015 and 2024, especially by analysing social media posts.

Chapter 1 Origins and Evolution of UN Communication Strategies

1.1 The role of communication in development

Sustainable development in the following research will be referred to as a concept defined by the Brundtland report, "development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs"[3] (World Commission on Environment and Development, 1987).

After defining the main concept, the role of communication in sustainable development and development will be discussed in detail. Communication in the sustainable development field fosters collaboration, spreads awareness and encourages behavioural changes. The exchange of information through dialogue enables inclusive policies which also supports educational initiatives that teach people sustainable decision-making skills. Firstly, it is vital to achieve a common understanding of sustainable communication before assessing the general role of communication. It can be described as "the sharing of knowledge aimed at reaching a consensus for action that takes into account the interests, needs and capacities of all concerned" (Servaes, 2003)[4]. Previously development communication was explained, however it is also important to understand the concept of sustainable communication. For the definition of sustainable communication, we can refer to Kannengießer (2021). According to the scholar sustainable communication is "all communicative practices, mediated or non-mediated, which deal with any aspect of sustainability (either related to the ecological, economic and/or social dimension)". [5] Hence, there is a contrast between the two. Sustainable communication takes a more holistic approach rather

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[3] WCED, S. W. S. (1987). World commission on environment and development. *Our common future*, *17*(1), 1-91.

[4] Servaes, J. (2003). *Approaches to Development Communication*. Paris: UNESCO. Available at: https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000135752

[5] Kannengießer, S. (2021). Media reception, media effects and media practices in sustainability communication: State of research and research gaps. *The Sustainability Communication Reader: A Reflective Compendium*, 323-338.

than development communication. It Integrates insights from various fields such as environmental science, communication studies, sociology, economics, and politics. Sustainable communication goes along with the SDG agenda, placing a focus on the accomplishment of the needs of current generations and future ones.

Before the 2015 UN agenda was revealed, communication was also important for development. The earliest paradigms in the modernisation theory. As one of the earlier scholars Schramm (1964) underlines that communication is an extremely powerful tool in promoting communication in developing countries. In other words, it was a driver in the modernization processes. Schramm the proponent of the theory that communication outlets such as radio, television, newspapers, and films can be used to deliver specific messages which in return will lead to modernisation. Looking from the scope of development and underdevelopment, countries which lack development usually have underdeveloped systems of communication, and the other way round. Role of media is quite significant for this theory, however the criticism of it can be its Eurocentric approach. However, despite it being written nearly 50 years before the announcements of sustainable development goals in 2015 it still can bring insights into why communication is a driver of SDG achievements. This modernisation paradigm aims at spreading the values of developed countries with a “top-down” manner through various media outlets.

The second approach is the dependency paradigm. The modernisation paradigm came under growing criticism in the 1970s for a number of reasons, including the fact that it expected progress to follow a constant, clearly defined linear sequence and ignored the importance of local social, political, and cultural context. Heavily influenced by Przeworski & Wallerstein’s (1982) “World system theory”, it became evident that comparing development between the rich and the poor is illogical. In this theory greater importance was granted to the state, rather than more developed nations. However, still similar to the modernisation

paradigm, the primary focus was on mass media, which were supposed to be governed by the state, having in mind that it would act in the public's best interests. However, this neo-Marxist paradigm was not very successful leading to the final approach.

By the end of the 20th century a pivotal turn has occurred in the communication of development. Thus, the third paradigm is the participatory one. With the rise of the internet and at the same time the movements of participatory development, focused on local communities (Kannengießer, 2023). Radio has especially played a great role in communicating certain ideas, since it was one of the most reachable media resources. Also, by 2000 under the development communication framework, the MDGs were created, highlighting the need of using media technology to empower people in less developed economies, which highlights the rising participatory approach. As the world society is moving towards globalism, the interconnectedness and communications intensify. Not only governmental actors play an important role in communications but also non-governmental actors. The more general idea of communication for social change is a more modern strategy in the field of development communication. In contrast to development communication, which has frequently been linked to modernisation and reliance, social change communication highlights the significance of societal change with the goal of attaining better social justice. This shows that communication is of high importance in the development process.

It is highlighted by Mulholland (2019) that the UN and the 2030 Agenda make it abundantly evident that the successful execution of the SDGs and the 2030 Agenda will depend heavily on the role played by the state and national governments. Effective implementation of the SDGs includes communication and awareness-raising. There is no “one size fits all” approach when it comes to country’s governments communicating sustainable development. Each state operates under its own circumstances and focuses on exact issues which are

nationally relevant. At the same time the UN carries out global campaigns to increase general knowledge and awareness of the 2030 agenda. However, despite communication being an important aspect, there are also other factors which influence the success of the programme. It is vital to understand that communication is not sufficient on its own. According to Zuev, Ostrovskaya, and Frolova (2017), achieving sustainable development requires not only social and environmental reforms but also economic prudence, particularly through the avoidance of unsustainable debt practices. As Zuev, Ostrovskaya, and Frolova (2017) highlight "This untenable level of borrowing is detrimental to global economic growth and resilience, and must be addressed if the international community hopes to accomplish the development goals shared by the world's largest economies and the United Nations"[6].

1.2 Overview of UN communication strategies prior to 2015 (MDGs era)

In the year 2000 the United Nations announced eight millennium development goals or MDGs which would aid less developed countries to overcome poverty and reduce inequalities. MDGs were aimed to eradicate extreme poverty and hunger, achieve universal primary education, promote gender equality and empower women, reduce child mortality, improve maternal health, combat HIV/AIDS, malaria, and other diseases, ensure environmental sustainability, and develop a global partnership for development. While fifteen years later not all of the MDGs were achieved, in 2015 the UN announced the sustainable development goals. The SDGs had a broader scope and contained 17 goals and were directed not solely towards undeveloped countries but towards all countries around the globe. The following research evidently focuses on the features of communication of SDGs; however, it is also crucial to discuss the communication strategy of MDGs since this provides context and general

[6] Zuev, V., Ostrovskaya, E., & Frolova, E. (2017). Sustainable economy: Do not use the debt widely. *International Organisations Research Journal*, *12*(4), 68-90.

background for understanding the evolution and progress in communications of sustainable development goals. As Van Norren (2012) points out, the millennium development goals turned out to be inefficient development tools, however their communication can be learned from and translated into the SDG agenda. Thus, an overview of UN communication strategies prior to 2015, in other words the millennium development era is necessary.

As Klaverweide (2006) highlights, the pillar of promoting MDGs was campaigning and mobilisation that would raise public awareness and tackle ignorance. Thus, at the Secretary General's request and on the UN Development Group's behalf, the UN Development Group carried out the Millennium Campaign. This public Millennium Campaign attempted to reach out the values of MDGs in order to promote the achievement of goals and their success. For this project the UN was responsible for communicating millennium development goals on three main levels: global, national and regional (or local). The United Nations Development Group has also taken part in communicating the MDGs. They have helped United Nations Country Teams to promote the main message of the MDG on a national level, by giving their expertise. Eveline Hefkins, originally a Dutch politician, was appointed executive coordinator for the Millennium Development Goals campaign. She was also responsible for carrying out the UN communication strategy of the MDG agenda on a global scale.

Campaigns are an integral part of communicating both MDGs and SDGs. It is one of the primary methods of communication, however other forms also exist such as educational programmes, reports, summits, conferences and social media platforms are all components of the communication strategy. Talking about campaigns during the SDG era, the campaign called “Make poverty history” was introduced in 2005 and focused on eradicating poverty and hunger (goal number one on the MDG agenda). Various NGOs, celebrities, activists led a high-profile campaign to raise awareness of the issue. The campaign also coincided with the

G8 summit in Scotland which encouraged world leaders to cancel debt and help developing countries with aid. In addition to the advertising, Live 8 showcased a number of artists to draw in viewers. The event raised awareness of the MDGs and was a component of the "Make Hunger History" campaign. Another prominent campaign of the MDGs was “Every woman every child” which was launched in 2010 and specifically addresses millennium development goals number four and number five. It aimed at reducing child mortality and improving maternal health. The campaign was supported by governments, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), the private sector, civil society, and international institutions. The communication was carried out through an official website made specifically for this campaign, also through collaborations with organisations such as UNICEF, and through social media outlets. The initiative later on transformed into Global Strategy for Women’s, Children’s and Adolescents’ Health (2016–2030) under the SDGs framework. The accountability of the campaign is controlled by IAP (international accountability panel), which controls reports of the campaign.

Collaboration is another communication strategy. Collaborations can be with NGOs, UN bodies or any other civil society actors. The Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis, and Malaria, or also known as the Global fund was established in 2002 and correlated with MDG number six. Its goal is the battle against malaria, TB, and HIV/AIDS—three of the deadliest illnesses in the world. It worked towards providing global access to treatment of the diseases, raising resources and awareness on the topic. It operates through collaborations at the national, regional, and international levels rather than directly implementing initiatives.

Thus, it is evident that prior to 2015, the main components of UN communication strategy during the MDGs era were traditional media outreach, high-profile events, cooperation with NGOs, top-down advocacy campaigns.

MDGs were not heavily promoted on social media platforms, rather SDGs became highly digitalized and were communicated through various social media outlets. Content analysis of social media posts will be carried out in the second chapter of the research.

1.3 The role of communication in achieving the 17 SDGs

As the MDG era ended in 2015, the UN announced another sustainable development programme. The new sustainable development agenda is described as "economic development, social inclusion, and environmental sustainability are the three tenets underpinning the forthcoming post-2015 development agenda, a once in a generation opportunity to put mankind on the path to a sustainable growth model" [7]by Sachs (2015). In this part, the role of communication strategy will be assessed from the scope of reaching the set 17 sustainable development goals. The sustainable development goals are no poverty, zero hunger, good health and well-being, quality education, gender equality, clean water and sanitation, affordable and clean energy, decent work and economic growth, industry, innovation, and infrastructure, reduced inequalities, sustainable cities and communities, responsible consumption and production, climate action, life below water, life on land, peace, justice and strong institutions, and partnerships for the goals. Even while the 2030 Agenda as a whole doesn't specifically address communication or how the UN or its Member States should go about spreading the 2030 Agenda and the SDGs, it is nevertheless possible to infer messages of communication from it. Hence, the role of communication in achieving the SDGs is vital to discuss. Effective and proactive communication is essential to the success of sustainable development initiatives. Through communication, it is essential that every party demonstrate their commitment to the idea of governance

[7] Sachs, J. D. (2015). Achieving the sustainable development goals. *Journal of International Business Ethics*, *8*(2), 53-62.

based on sustainable development principles. In other words, sustainable development goals are achieved through active communications.

Globalisation has made it possible for intercultural communication to occur. Cross cultural communication is an integral part of the UN's SDG communication strategy. It is important to deliver a message in a way which would be understandable for different cultures, different religions and contrasting languages. If a communicator delivers the message in an inefficient way, it may even bring harm to the achievements of the sustainable development goals agenda. It is impossible to overstate the significance of establishing and preserving effective communication throughout human society. The community is held together and maintained by effective communication. As Aririguzoh (2022) points out, the United Nations understands the cross-cultural dynamic and their role in sustainable development. Irrelevant cultural communication can hinder the success of SDG programmes. By acknowledging that efforts should be both locally and culturally relevant, the SDGs are more meaningful and easily attainable.

Communication is also important since it can translate complex concepts into accessible and explicit messages which will be available for understanding. Since the audience of the SDG agenda is diverse and includes governments, corporations, smaller business, NGOs, individuals and many others, messages should be reachable to every target audience. Thus, it is important for the United Nations to create such a message which will be understood by many. For example, the SDG campaign called “Act Now” introduced in December of 2018, works on SDG thirteen (action against climate change). It is a social movement which uses simple wording and popular social media platforms to engage with the audience. The creation of an app where people can log in and track their actions, which help actions against climate change. This is an example of how the UN translates a

complex issue of climate change into a fun activity which engages people to contribute towards achieving SDG 13.

Also, the UN emphasises the importance of multi-sided dialogue and encourages stakeholders to hear marginalised voices. A well-thought-out collaborative communications strategy is crucial for helping UN teams and partners drive narratives, achieve achievements, and mobilise significant target groups, according to the United Nations Sustainable Development Group (2022). Campaigns such as “HeForShe” launched by the UN support SDG five and strives towards removing gender-based discrimination. Using storytelling to humanise numbers and provide accessible narratives is part of the campaign's communication strategy. For example, celebrities such as Emma Watson have delivered a speech on the topic when the campaign was launched. Also, hashtags “#HeForShe” were used across social media where people have shared their personal stories. Hence, storytelling, viral media content and use of celebrities in campaigns can drive tangible progress for SDGs.

Therefore, in order to ensure inclusive, transparent, and long-lasting progress towards global development, effective communication is crucial for accomplishing the 17 SDGs since it increases awareness, mobilises stakeholders, encourages accountability, and stimulates cooperation.

1.4 Channels of communication used by the United Nations used in promoting SDGs

The United Nations uses a wide spectrum of tools and channels to communicate the messages of the SDG agenda. The UN uses both the traditional forms of media and more contemporary ones for dissemination of sustainable values.

From traditional media the UN uses channels of communication such as radio, television and newspapers. News agencies such as BBC or New York time and many others shed light on high profile events of the UN which are connected to sustainability. Also, the UN uses globally recognised days such as for example World Environment Day to raise awareness about the SDG agenda. For instance, on June 5, 2024, Secretary-General António Guterres issued a statement highlighting the theme "land restoration, desertification, and drought resilience", (Guterres, 2024).

Furthermore, the UN uses more and more digital platforms for its communication strategy. Websites and online portals are an integral tool of the United Nations nowadays. The official UN SDG website (sdgs.un.org) provides full information and all the relevant data about each of the goals, their achievements, statistics, reports and many more. Also, the UN has specialised websites for specific campaigns, for example the site for "ActNow" which was mentioned earlier in the first chapter. Moreover, UN has multiple social media accounts such as Twitter, Facebook[8], Instagram[9], YouTube, and LinkedIn. Each of the social media platforms engages with a different audience. For example, LinkedIn is aimed at more professional updates and advocacy efforts towards SDGs and SDG reports. While Twitter provides daily updates and news on global issues. Instagram[10] engages younger users and employs viral content or challenges to attract views and promote the SDG agenda through visuals (photographs or videos).

Moreover, official reports and documents which the United Nations provides is also a channel of communication of the sustainable development

[8] Facebook (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[9] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[10] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

programme. Policy briefs are published for governments or corporations to advance their actions or alter their strategy for specific goals. Annual SDG reports assess global progress toward achieving the 17 goals, highlighting successes, challenges, and areas for improvement.

Finally, high-level events and conferences hosted by the UN provide a platform for dialogues and mobilisation of resources. Real life events are also a method of putting forward a message. The 2021 Food Systems Summit aimed to accelerate progress toward SDG 2 (Zero Hunger) by promoting sustainable agricultural practices and food security policies.

Thus, the United Nations has an array of tools through which it can implement its communication strategy. Traditional media, social media platforms, events and official documents or reports are all channels of communication. The next two chapters will investigate how the features of the communication strategy have been altered throughout the years, particularly media platforms and official documents and reports will be looked at in detail.

Chapter 2 Content Analysis of UN Reports and Social Media

2.1 Content analysis of UN Communication strategy: methodology

In the second chapter of the research a method of qualitative and quantitative content analysis will be employed to investigate how the features of the United Nations' communication strategy evolve in the context of the sustainable development goals agenda from 2014 to 2015. Content analysis will be particularly relevant to test the hypothesis since content analysis aids to systematically analyse text and identify certain patterns. Shifts in language, or on the contrary continuation of language patterns will allow to trace the evolution of communication strategy. In other words, content analysis will trace changes or stability.

- *Explanation for the choice of methodology*

Before starting the explanation of the research procedure, it is important to understand the choice of the methodology. Small number of marker words (in this case four and six) aligns with the principle of concept validity. In other words, each of the words explains one of the angles of the hypothesis. As Krippendooff (2018) quotes, "Researchers may code for the presence or the absence of particular words, themes, or content features in texts to make valid inferences"[11]. This quote supports the strategy chosen in this content analysis, because a limited set of carefully chosen words will be used to track the evolution of UN communication strategy.

[11] Krippendorff, K. (2018). *Content Analysis: An Introduction to Its Methodology* (4th ed.). SAGE Publications

Moreover, the scholae Neuendorf (2017) supports the idea of using targeted words or phrases in the content analysis, especially when examining a change or a pattern. She advocates for the method of choosing a small and purposeful set of words to track them across time period. Neuendorf (2017) highlights "A limited set of key terms, selected for their relevance to the research question, can be sufficient to produce meaningful findings"[12] .

- *Data Collection*

The analysis will draw upon two main types of data, which are official United Nations sustainable development reports and the UN social media reports. These two formats will be complementary to each other and fulfil different roles.

The reports are an institutional and formal way of communication. Annual UN SDG reports are sourced from an official United Nations website (https://sdg.un.org.) and are published once a year to track the completion of the seventeen global goals. The analysis of these reports will give an opportunity to assess the formal progress. One report per year was sampled, starting from 2016, since in 2015 SDGs were only announced. Overall, 9 reports were sampled for content analysis.

On the other hand, social media posts were randomly sampled. 3 main social media platforms which are Instagram,[13] Facebook[14] and X (prior Twitter). These platforms were selected since they are the three most popular ones by followers, apart from Tik Tok. Tik Tok was removed from the selection, since it mainly concentrates on visual content, while for the given research written content is more

[12] Neuendorf, K. A. (2017). *The Content Analysis Guidebook* (2nd ed.). SAGE Publications.
[13] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[14] Facebook (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

relevant. Also, TikTok appeared only after 2016, which does not match the time frame. Solely official UN accounts were used to find social media posts.

One representative post is chosen per platform. For instance, one Instagram [15]post, one X post and one Facebook[16] post per year. Therefore, overall, thirty posts are selected for the given time frame. Posts are sampled randomly within a given year, since this increases the data pool. Random sampling is applied to avoid any biases by selecting only the most popular posts or the promoted ones. The criteria for selection are solely the given year (from 2015 to 2024) and relation to SDG. In other words, the post must contain information about the SDG agenda, sustainable development or contain hashtags such as "#ActNow" and "#GlobalGoals".

- *Time frame and periodization*

To identify the evolution and a general pattern the pre-given 10-year period which is from 2015 to 2024 was divided in three separate and distinct phases. The separation was created in such a way that it follows the chronological order of global events and the hypothesis. Period one is from 2015 to 2017. The three years correlate with the introduction of sustainable goals agenda and raising awareness of the global goals. Period two is from 2018 to 2021. This era marks the Covid-19 pandemic and will test the period of crisis and raise attention on support. Period three is from 2022 to 2024. This three-year gap will test the localization hypothesis, which may have occurred after the coronavirus pandemic. This division will be able to group years in a way which will enable us to assess how the UN's communication strategy changed overtime. The whole period from 2015 to 2024 will be tested for increasing digitization.

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[15] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[16] Facebook (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

- *Marker and word selection*

To conduct the analysis marker words were selected based on the topic and the relevance of the hypothesis. Since the hypothesis is two-folded two aspects have to be tested. The first one is the presence of the digitalization process and the second one is the features of the communication strategy: from global awareness and knowledge building (2015 – 2017), to engagement and support during the pandemic crisis (2018 – 2021) and finally a more localized approach (2022-2024).

Separate sets of words were used for report content analysis and for social media content analysis. The selection was guided both by deductive method, meaning based on theoretical knowledge, and by inductive method, meaning that text was scanned preliminary to the analysis. For social media six words were selected, while for the reports four. The difference in the number of marker words can be explained by the length of reports. Amount of data and text in the UN SDG reports is larger than in social media posts. Each marker word is intended to represent a feature embedded in the communication strategy of the United Nations.

Marker words selected for the report analysis are: digital, local, global, support.

Marker words selected for social media posts analysis are: partner, action, local, engage crisis, future. Below are the codebooks:

Table 1

(Table 1 showing the codebook for report content analysis)

Marker Word	Meaning
Digital	Allows to trace the use of digital tools and communication methods. The marker word will give an understanding of online presence.
Local	Examines regional and community-specific communication. Aligns with the participatory approach.
Global	Measures continued emphasis on universal messaging and worldwide engagement.
Support	Assesses references to assistance and aid.

Table 2

(Table 2 showing the codebook for social media content analysis)

Marker Word	Meaning
Partner	Tracks mutual engagements as well collaborations, whether interstate collaborations or any other forms.
Action	Oversees mobilization and campaign activity, as well as serves as a “call for action” reference.
Local	Examines regional and community-specific communication. Aligns with the participatory approach.

Engage	Marker word for understanding interaction with the audience and active participation in SDG agenda.
Crisis	Reflects impacts of emergencies or any other global or local extraordinary situations with a negative impact.
Future	Identifies forward-looking framing and motivation towards sustainability.

- *Coding procedure*

In the coding procedure there were two steps. Firstly, all the marker words were manually identified throughout the texts and counted year by year. In social media posts, words were highlighted and then counted by hand. In UN SDG reports the marker words were scanned for their appearance. After the mentioned procedure, words were aggregated across three periods. This would represent main trends in the communication strategy.

The results were later visualized using Excel. Word frequencies were translated into line graphs for better visualization of the results. This also simplified the evaluation stage.

- *Validation and limitation of the content analysis research*

To ensure internal validity, completely different types of data were sources. Reports and social media posts most likely have different target audiences. However, if marker words will correlate in both cases this will set a clear pattern

for UN's communication strategy and prove that it is quite consistent. Another strength is that all data was publicly available in open resources online.

The limitations of the content analysis may be that sample sizes are relatively small. Big data analysis is not employed in the following research. Reliance only on keywords may not capture the context or the tone of voice, while the random sampling may omit viral content. However, the tone of voice as well viral content or challenges initiated by the United Nations will be assed in the third chapters through case studies.

2.2 Content analysis of UN Communication strategy: results

The results of the described above content analysis will be presented below. The data from the results will be shown both individually and grouped by time periods.

- *Social media posts content analysis results*

Table 3

(Table 3 showing the total number of count words by each category in social media posts)

Marker word	**Count**
Partner	5
Action	24
Local	1
Engage	2
Crisis	3
Future	11

Table 4

(Table 4 showing the distribution of marker words by categories by year in social media posts)

Year	Partner	Action	Local	Engage	Crisis	Future
2015	3	3	0	0	0	1
2016	1	1	0	0	0	1
2017	0	0	0	0	0	0
2018	0	1	0	1	0	1
2019	0	3	0	0	0	0
2020	0	1	0	0	3	2
2021	0	2	0	0	0	0
2022	1	10	1	1	0	3
2023	0	1	0	0	0	2
2024	0	2	0	0	0	1

Table 5

(Table 5 showing the distribution of marker words by categories across time periods in social media posts)

Period	Partner	Action	Local	Engage	Crisis	Future
2015 - 2017	4	4	0	0	0	2
2018 - 2021	0	7	0	1	3	3
2022 - 2024	1	13	1	1	0	6

- *United Nations sustainable development goals report content analysis result*

Table 6

(Table 6 showing the total number of count words by each category in UN SDG reports)

Marker Word	Count
Digital	72
Local	123
Global	1718
Support	304

Table 7

(Table 7 showing the distribution of marker words by categories by year in UN SDG reports)

Year	Digital	Local	Global	Support
2016	2	3	117	12
2017	1	8	156	25
2018	0	4	115	27
2019	2	13	153	25
2020	3	21	221	33
2021	4	12	193	54
2022	3	16	211	33
2023	47	36	294	68
2024	10	10	258	27

Table 8
(Table 8 showing the distribution of marker words by categories across time periods in UN SDG reports)

Period	Digital	Local	Global	Support
2016–2017	3	11	273	37
2018–2021	9	50	682	139
2022–2024	60	62	763	128

- *Data visualisation*

Please see images of data visualization in appendix (graph 1 and graph 2)

- *Data description*

Looking at content analysis of social media posts a total of six marker words were used (partner, action, local, engage, crisis, future). Words partner had five counts across the thirty selected posts across three social media, word action had twenty-four counts, word local was found one time, word engagement was spotted two times, word crisis was found three times and word future only once. Word action was the most popular and frequent word across all time periods. From 2022 to 2024 it was the most frequently used word in social media posts. Crisis had its peak number from 2018 to 2021 and was not seen in any other time periods. Word local appears only once from 2022 to 2024. Engage also appears once in each of the last two time periods. The word future has a good word count, and is the second most popular word after action. Ranging from two to six in each of the time frames. Word partner mainly appeared during the 2015-2017 period, a total of five times.

Regarding the content analysis of UN SDG reports, four marker words were tracked across the nine SDG reports from 2016 to 2024: digital, local, global, and support. The word digital was not used very often in the first two periods, three and nine times exactly. However, the word count drastically increased in the last time period, to being mentioned sixty times. The year 2023 was the most popular among the word digital. The word local appeared with greater regularity throughout the reports. Its word count increased from a low of 3 in 2016 to a peak of 36 in 2023. The count fluctuated across other years, with notable growth during the 2018–2021 period and continuing into 2022–2024. Moving to the word global. The word global was the most consistent one out of all the rest marker words. It was also the most popular one, appearing 1718 times. Its word count ranged from 117 to 294 across all years. It remained consistently above 150 from the year 2017. Lastly, the word support was the second most popular after the word global. It showed persistent presence across all of the reports during the nine-year time span. For example, in 2016 it appeared only 12 times and then started to gradually grow. It peaked in 2023 with 68 counts. Particularly it was present from 2018 to 2021 with 138 total mentions.

When comparing across both data sources, the global marker word showed the highest overall count, consistently dominating the UN SDG reports. The Digital marker word rose sharply in 2023 but remained relatively low outside of that year. For social media posts content analysis, action emerged as the dominant word, growing significantly in the last time period. In this part no interpretations or analysis were provided, the core focus of this part was to show the results and describe them. The following part will draw conclusions from the gathered data from content analysis.

2.3 Content analysis of UN Communication strategy: evaluation of results

The content analysis presented above done both with social media posts and official documents published by the United Nations show insights into how the UN's communication strategy altered over time. By content analysis it is possible to identify main features of the communication strategy. Aligning with the hypothesis there have been both alterations in the form as well as content of strategic messaging. This evaluation of results draws upon quantitative patterns which were described earlier on and compares them to the hypothesis. Firstly, digitalisation will be analysed, and secondly the shift of features across time periods from 2015 to 2024 will be taken into consideration.

To start with, the hypothesis of digitalisation as a medium of communication will be looked at through the scope of content analysis. The first level of hypothesis proposed that digital instruments and online tools will be more evident and important with time. Digital platforms would enhance UN's global reach and accessibility to the target audience. Frequency of the marker word digital in UN reports supports the claim of the hypothesis. While the term appeared to be uncommon from 2015 to 2021, in 2023 the word counts spiked. And the period from 2022 to 2024 turned out to be the time frame with the most common usage of the word digital. This jump initiates the long institutional changes and the digital transformation which might have appeared after the global pandemic. Digitalisation was not immediately apparent however after three years after the start of Covid-19 pandemic, it became evident that digitalisation is on the rise. The rise of the use of the terminology digital suggests that there was a formal recognition of digital tools. Therefore, according to the United Nations SDG reports, digitalisation became more relevant. Despite the fact that in social media posts content analysis, the marker word digital was not used, the rising use of the word action, which was steadily increasing across all three time periods, reveals

an increased online interaction and more efforts onto mobilisation online and through the use of digital platforms. This also reinforces the idea that the UN started to use more and more digital tools to reach their message to the audience through social media, which are undoubtedly online and digital platforms.

Secondly, the hypothesis of shifting features will be tested in accordance with the data collected from the content analysis. The second level of the hypothesis stated that the UN's communication strategy would evolve across three phases. From global awareness and knowledge building (2015–2017), to increased engagement and support during a crisis (2018–2021), and then to a localized, community focused model, while still maintaining a digital scope (2022–2024).

During the primary phase (2015-2017) the word global appeared very frequently in the UN sustainable development annual reports, a total of 273 mentions. This suggests that the United Nations institutions were trying to emphasise the global scope of the 2030 agenda through official documents. Other marker words do show to be prominent. An evaluation can be made that the first three year since the introduction of the global goals, the United Nations were putting an accent on the universality of the SDG agenda, and trying to bring a message to the audience that the globality of the agenda and its universality is the main aspect of the SDG programme. In the social media posts, words like partner and action were more prevalent during this period, suggesting a vision-setting stage where the UN prioritized coalition-building and mobilisation of efforts.

The second phase (2018-2021) is the middle period whereby the UN's abilities to support countries through the SDG agenda as well as the appearance of the crisis itself was tested. The word crisis emerged in social media posts, solely in the second time frame, signalling that the United Nations is using responsive and adaptive messaging to external factors. Moreover, the marker word support

and engage rose in count, particularly the word support rose in counts in the UN SDG reports, peaking in 2021 at 54 counts. This data suggests that during the times of crisis and emergency the United Nations emphasised solidarity, resilience, and shared responsibility. The recurring motif which can be noticed from 2018 to 2021 is the word action. In social media posts it increased, which suggests that the UN's communicative language encouraged everyone to participate in common efforts and take immediate actions.

Finally, the third stage from 2022 to 2024, hypothesised that more focus would be given to local issues and community-based attention. In the UN reports the word count local reached the highest frequencies of 36 in 2023 and remained notable both in 2022 and 2024. In social media posts, the marker local also appeared for the first time in the third time frame. While the word global remained the most dominant term overall, the rise of marker word local indicates a dual focus—maintaining the global agenda while recognizing the value of tailored, localized approaches. In social media posts the marker words future and action were the most popular ones, emphasising mobilisation. What is interesting is that the frequency of the word partner declined sharply and appeared only once in the final time frame. However, localisation was not exclusive for this sole time frame and appeared in other periods as for example in 2019 it appeared a total of 13 times. This suggests that in this part the hypothesis has to be disapproved. Localisation was not exclusive to only that time period.

To compare the content analysis of reports and social media posts, it is evident that these two sources of communication carry very different purposes. Reports are the depiction of scale formality. Even the high frequency of the word global shows that universal messaging remains foundational for the institution. In contrast, social media appears more reactive and engaging. Words like crisis and action reflect the real-time nature of social platforms and also present a focus on audience activation and public participation. Moreover, the spike in the word

digital in 2023 UN reports but not in earlier years or social posts may indicate a delayed formal acknowledgment of shifts already well underway in public communication.

Overall, the approach taken for content analysis has proved to be effective for the following investigation and clearly revealed the evolving features of the UN's communication strategy from 2015 to 2024. By systematically tracking marker words across both official UN reports and social media posts, the analysis captured shifts in tone, audience targeting, and messaging priorities.

Chapter 3 Evaluation of Strategic Features through Case Studies

3.1 Case study research

The third and final chapter presents three separate in-depth case studies of campaigns carried out by the United Nations in the field of sustainable development and with an aim of promoting SDGs. The case study method is employed in the following part of the research to investigate concrete examples of the ways in which the United Nations has communicated the sustainable development goals. While previous chapters focused on content analysis of reports and social media posts to trace broader and more explicit trends, the third chapter will add depth and context by analyzing specific campaigns that exemplify the evolving nature of the UN's communication strategy.

This particular method was chosen for the last chapter of the research because it is an effective qualitative tool for researching real - world phenomena. As Tellis (1994) suggests "an empirical investigation of a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context is one situation in which case study methodology is applicable"[17]. This method will complement the previously used method of content analysis. That can be explained by the fact that a case study allows to carry out a more nuanced analysis and give more detail, in comparison to content analysis which captures word frequencies and general themes. Case studies give a chance to assess how the UN's communication strategy looks like and how the messages evolve over certain time periods. It will expose through which platforms the UN delivers its message and in what ways, whether it be educational content and entertainment style campaigns.

[17] Tellis, W. (1997). Application of a case study methodology. *The qualitative report*, *3*(3), 1-19.

- *Choice of campaigns for case studies*

The campaigns that are chosen for the 3 case studies differ in format and the theme that they are campaigning in. Hence, the three campaigns which will be analysed in the case studies are “Tell Everyone”, “Choose Life” and ‘Halftime”. “Tell Everyone” campaign was launched in 2015. This is one of the first campaigns to be launched by the UN in the spectrum of SDG agenda. The overall aim of this specific campaign is to raise awareness about all the 17 goals of the SDG agenda. Appeared majorly between 2015 and 2016. The second campaign which will be looked at in detail is the “Choose Life” campaign started in 2020. The campaign’s goal is to take action against climate change and to change lifestyles in accordance with helping the environment. A UK-based climate action campaign was developed in collaboration with the UN SDG Action Campaign and the UK government. The final campaign which will be taken into consideration ‘Halftime” started in 2023 and highlights that a half of the SDG deadline has passed, in other words it shines lights on the momentum of halftime. It emphasises the need to recommit to the goals and to continue striving for success.

During the case studies, the research will zoom into specific and most prominent moments of the campaigns, which will reveal strategic shifts of the UN communication strategy. As Yin (2018) recommends it is crucial to concentrate on specific milestones when conducting a case study. This approach also correlates with the research question, where concentration on specific periods will allow to trace the evolution of the features of the United Nations’ communication strategy for sustainable development goals between 2015 and 2024. The goal of this case study is not to represent the campaign as a whole, but rather its peak moments, to illustrate the main features of the UN communication strategy and its changes.

The three campaigns were intentionally chosen from three different time periods and with different thematic approaches. Tell Everyone (2015), Choose Life (2020), and Halftime (2023) all contribute to investigating the features of the UN communication strategy, but are all different in their scopes. Tell Everyone is a global scale campaign launched in the same year as the sustainable development goals were announced, Choose Life is a climate initiative on a national scale, Halftime is also a global campaign, however it started at the midpoint of the 2030 Agenda. It will be also useful to compare how different are the campaigns from 2015 and 2023 that have a global approach. This deliberate diversity in campaign selection allows the study to capture a communication strategy shift from 2015 to 2024. Together, the three selected campaigns span the full research time frame of 2015 to 2024.

- *Conducting the case study*

Each campaign will be analysed according to four dimensions, which will create a comprehensible lens for research. Which are the background and context of the campaign, messaging techniques and framing, media and platforms and strategic features. Firstly, background and context will give general data about the campaign and will emerge into the context of the UN's initiative. This will include interpreting campaign decisions, such as audience targeting or thematic focus. Secondly, messaging techniques and framing which analyse slogans, tones and overall narrative. Next, media and platforms criteria will identify platforms and media types, through which digitalisation can be analysed. The final dimension, analysis of strategic features, will critically analyse the other criteria and come to a conclusion about how the campaign reflects trends such as digital shift, global-to-local transitions, increased participatory focus or actions in times of crises.

3.2 Case study: Tell Everyone Campaign (2015)

- *Background and Context*

The Tell Everyone campaign was introduced in 2015. It was the identical year when the United Nations announced the seventeen sustainable development goals. Despite the fact that the new and ambitious agenda was set and goals had to be reached by 2030, the SDG programme was far from well-known and the majority of people were ignorant about it (Project Everyone, 2025). The campaign was delivered in partnership with the United Nations and Project Everyone, as well as the UN Department of Public Information. Project Everyone, which is a creative agency working with the UN to promote SDGs in a unique and interesting way, commented on the launch of the campaign with the following words "We set our sights on a new ambition, of reaching seven billion people in seven days". [18] This citation creates a notion that preparation of the campaign has taken a week which was a strenuous process and a challenging one. It was a global and universal campaign incorporating multiple stakeholders such as the country's governments including ministries, creative communities and organisations, radio stations, volunteers and even mobile operators. Richard Curtis was the creative director of the campaign. It was a campaign about teaching the world of the SDGs and getting acquainted with the concept of sustainable development. The target audience of the campaign was the whole world population, which did not know about the 2030 agenda. The following UN SDG campaign wanted to reach everyone of all ages and nationalities, as well as governments and businesses. The goals of the Tell Everyone campaign lies in its title to inform about the new SDG agenda. The campaign is the result of an institutional milestone: a transfer from MDG to SDG

[18] Project Everyone. (2025). *10 Years of Impact: Project Everyone Impact Report*. https://project-everyone.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/HS471-PE-Impact-Report_Digital-FINAL.pdf

agenda. It was designed as a multimedia, multi-platform global activity. The campaign Tell Everyone involved an extensive network of media outlets, celebrities, influencers, digital companies, NGOs, and educational partners.

- *Messaging techniques and framing*

The Tell everyone campaign used various messaging techniques. One of the most vivid ones is storytelling which can be seen in a YouTube video "We the people" (part of the content of the campaign) where celebrities deliver a message in a storytelling format. Actors, musicians, scientists share the importance of SDGs, making the 2030 agenda feel more accessible due to the appearance of public figures. Given the complexity and scale of the 2030 Agenda—comprising 17 goals and 169 targets—the campaign's key communication challenge was to simplify and to make the campaign more humanised. The slogan and simultaneously the name of the campaign "Tell Everyone" signifies a call for action. If an individual found out or has information about the sustainable development goals, he/she should share the knowledge with others. Responsibility lies within individuals, not solely governments or the UN, is a clear message of the campaign. However, still the campaign was messaged through a top-down approach.

Overall, the strategic framing of the campaign has very positive and appealing tones, there is negativity, crisis or emergency language. The SDG agenda is presented in a very hopeful and optimistic way, motivating the people to strive for the future goals (Saxena, 2017). It is also noticeable that the campaign is tailored towards different cultures and countries. Despite universal actions, many countries such as India or Brazil have voiced the Tell Everyone campaign in their own manner. Materials were translated and localised to accommodate cultural and linguistic diversity. In other words, the campaign framed the SDGs not as a Western agenda, but as a truly global blueprint.

- *Media and platforms*

The platforms used by the UN to promote the campaign were both online and offline. Starting with real-life platforms. State ministries were involved in the promotion of the campaign, particularly the Ministries of Education. An equal of one hundred and three Ministries of Education supported the Tell Everyone campaign and committed towards teaching and giving basic information about the SDG agenda to their students, which reflects a top-down approach. Moreover, about one hundred and thirty-six countries raised their national flags to show global unity and support for the SDGs. A similar activity was supported by the United Nations which have illustrated the symbols and visual pictures of the Global Goals onto their buildings. An offline event which supported the campaign in 2015 was called the Global Citizen festival. It was broadcasted nearly in all the countries worldwide and was attended by high-ranking individuals and celebrities. The headliners of the festival were famous people such as Beyonce. Richard Curtis has diffused the Tell Everyone content across the festival, delivering the universal messages to the attendants and viewers.

Touching the theme of digital platforms. According to Project Everyone (2025) statistics mobile operators reached over 925 million customers with messages abounding the SDG agenda. Moreover, according to Project Everyone (2025) statistics, radio programmes in seventy-five countries have presented audio streaming content to announce the 2030 agenda. A YouTube video “We the People” which got over four million views (as of April, 2025) has represented a number of people and their stories of passion for specific SDG goals, in a way delivering information about each and every seventeen goals. Figures such as Stephen Hawking, Jennifer Lawrence, Jennifer Lopez, Matt Damon, Meryl Streep, Malala Yousafzai, Aamir Khan and Meryl Streep and many other famous people have participated in the video. Specific countries such as Brazil and India have also impacted the campaign. For example, in Brazil three comedy films were released which got over twenty-three million views on YouTube as claimed by

Project Everyone (2025). While in India the production of series by Yash Raj Films which shone light on the SDG programme, was trending number one on YouTube a day after the video was posted as shown by Project Everyone (2025). These are also examples of national actions on sustainability made to transfer the message into a global one through tools of social media.

- *Analysis of Strategic Features*

The Tell Everyone campaign exemplifies the early stage of the United Nations' evolving communication strategy for the Sustainable Development Goals agenda. It is a simple multi-stakeholder campaign the goal of which is to make the world acquainted with the 2030 agenda. It is characterised by global-awareness building and using hybrid platforms to translate a message (online and offline). The target audience of the campaign were all seven billion people which had to be reached. Tell Everyone put scale and simplicity, as well as primitive messaging into a priority. This ensured that the goals were presented in a way that was accessible to all audiences regardless of age, education level, or geographic location and so on. It was a campaign with positive messaging, mainly communicated through YouTube video as well as offline activities and government structures. From a technological standpoint, while not yet fully "digital-first" in the modern sense. Tell Everyone lacked strong participatory elements such as user-generated content and employed mainly a top-down approach. The main social media content was the video, while other messages were delivered on offline format or through radio. It laid the groundwork for future SDG campaigns and set the principle that global goals require a global approach.

3.3 Case study: Choose Life Campaign (2020)

- *Background and Context*

The Choose Life campaign was launched in October of 2020 in collaboration with Project Everyone, as well as the The Climate Coalition. Project

Everyone is a non-profit organisation with an approach of creative agency which communicates SDG goals in an artistic way, including various ways such as unique events, films, short videos and organised campaigns. TCC is a UK organisation which works towards climate change. The foundation of the campaign was an educational and awareness film, called Choose Life, which correlates with the name of the actual SDG campaign. The slogan "Choosing Life" directly means that governments and people should come together and protect the environment from damaging events which climate change can bring about. As The Global Goals Organisation (2020) points out the film was "designed to send a very clear message to the UK government: Now is the time to do the right thing, and take advantage of these unprecedented times to avoid reverting back to our old ways". [19]The film was directed by Adam Smith and the script for the film was written by Mike Benson. The main goal of the film and the SDG campaign was to bring awareness and shine light on the dilemma of climate change. It is important to note that the campaign was launched in 2020 in the period of the Covid-19 pandemic. Global Goals Organisation (2020) notices that the pandemic showed the fragility of the world in emergencies, where all the systems both economic and political ones come under pressure. The film illustrates new opportunities which can be taken by the UK to recover from such a shock. Choose Life captures mainly two sustainable development goals which are Goal 3 and Goal 13. Development goal 3 is about health and well-being, while development goal 13 is about climate action. It is a symbiosis of health and climate change which are interconnected and vital for sustainable development. Initially, it was a national campaign which escalated towards a global level being an integral part of the UN communication strategy in 2020. It is a limited campaign and not an ongoing initiative.

- *Messaging techniques and framing*

Firstly, the main slogan and title of the campaign is "Choose Life" which means that people and government need to move forward and look into the future.

[19] The Global Goals. (2020). *Choose life*. https://www.globalgoals.org/news/choose-life/

It coincides with the idea that a recovery after the global pandemic is very much needed, as well the preservation of the environment is crucial to protect the lives of many. The core message and phrase which is said in the monologues in a film is "We are at a crossroads – choose life or choose extinction."[20] The film stresses urgency and moral responsibility. The campaign uses strong emotional imagery and language to evoke concern, empathy, and even fear, making climate inaction feel personal. The simplicity here lies in the fact that primitive language is used which translates into a vivid message understandable to the audience. The slogan "Choose Life" is repeated in videos and social media to stick in the viewer's mind. One of the campaign's most defining features was its repurposing of the iconic monologue from the 1996 film Trainspotting, transforming it into a compelling call for climate responsibility.

- *Media and platforms*

The mechanics of Choose Life campaign were hybrid, employing both online and offline platforms.

Firstly, as it was already mentioned it was the film itself which was carrying a message. The movie also was supported by different online platforms. The online platform had multiple functions, such as an educational role, multiple resources, information and guides which raised the knowledge of the audience on how to "choose life'. It was also a tool for expressing political advice to the members of parliament (MP) on the issue of climate change. The fact that the collaboration includes TCC, the organisation is striving towards a more environmentally friendly and healthy future. This is done through signing of declaration. The declaration was signed by a number of prominent companies such as Tesco, Sky, BAFTA, Selfridges and also popular individuals such as Liam Gallagher, Ellie Goulding, Annie Lennox, Sunetra Sarker, Luke Evans (The Global Goals Organisation, 2020). The signatures aim towards post-pandemic

[20] Project Everyone. (2021). Choose life. The Global Goals. https://www.globalgoals.org/news/choose-life/

recovery. Touching the subject of social media, the film was promoted on Instagram[21] on the official account of the Global Goals Organisation (@theglobalgoals). Online, the campaign was supported by famous people such as Lewis Cel Spellman, Hamilton and Coldplay. Annie Lennox and Luke Evans appear in campaign content, reading scripts. Also, the song "Tell Everybody" was composed and sung by famous artists and musicians from Africa.

Moving to the offline platforms, the movie was showcased at 26th Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change or COP26. Particularly, it was shown in the blue zone. Blue Zone is an official space where main negotiations and discussion take place.

Moving to the results, according to Project Everyone (2025) impact report the Choose Life campaign had over four hundred thousand views and became the most viewed campaign of The Climate Coalition in terms of organic content on their Instagram [22]feed.

- *Analysis of Strategic Features*

The Choose Life campaign launched in 2020 uses a spectrum of strategic features to convey the message to the audience. It is also a great example, illustrating one of many UN campaigns which shape the communication strategy of the United Nations. It is a blend of appeal to emotion type of messaging, nationally targeted campaign (to the UK citizens) and hybrid format, employing both digital and real-life platforms to promote Choose Life campaign. It is strategically framed under SDG 13 and SDG 3. The campaign morally persuades to change the behaviour and alter lifestyle choices for a better future. The campaign also exemplifies how a localized (national scale) communication approach can be employed within a global framework. The campaign was most likely directed at the target audience of millennials, since the Choose Life

[21] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[22] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

campaign references the movie "Trainspotting" released in the year 1996. It is evident that the decision of the UN in collaboration with other organisations to anchor a global message within a national media and linguistic context reflects a shift in UN strategy towards localization approach of global goals, especially as the SDGs moved from the introductory phase into implementation. From a technological standpoint the campaign used social media and online platforms to deliver the messages, which correlates with modern technological trends. It is crucial to notice that the campaign stands on the message of altering individual behaviour, rather than promoting institutional reform. The campaign shows that initially it is important to start making changes by yourself. The campaign also lacked a participatory approach.

To sum up, the Choose Life campaign reflects a quite mature stage of UN communication strategy. It is localised but with a global outreach, it has cultural adaptation and uses digital platforms to deliver the message.

3.4 Case study: Halftime Campaign (2023)

- *Background and Context*

The Halftime campaign was launched in 2023, eight years after the announcement of the 2030 agenda. It is evident that half of the time for achievement of the SDG has gone by. As Global Goals Organisation (2023) points out "in 2015, 193 world leaders agreed on the #GlobalGoals, a game plan to change the world by 2030. Today, at halftime, we're losing – with only 15% of our Goals on track"[23]. This campaign is a signal of alarm that more effort has to be put into achieving the sustainable development goals. The progress of the SDG goals was hindered by the global pandemic, conflicts and climate crisis. The campaign's main goal is to recommit for another "halftime". The Halftime

[23] Global Goals. (2023). *Halftime: A wake-up call for the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).* Retrieved April 26, 2025, from https://www.globalgoals.org/halftime/

Campaign coincided with key events such as the SDG Summit 2023, where world leaders gathered to assess progress and recalibrate strategies. One of the main partners of the following campaign was the UN Office for Partnerships, other partners also included Bloomberg TV, Warner Bros and others. The campaign strives to mobilise all the societal sectors. In other words, it is a universal campaign, with the world population being the target audience of the given UN campaign. The foundation of the Halftime campaign was a film which depicted an altered Al Pacino's monologue from the "Inch by Inch". The speech was a remake to fit into the theme of global goals. Parallel to the film, a webpage on the global goal's official website was created.

- *Messaging techniques and framing*

The halftime campaign mainly employed sports themed messaging as a way to motivate the audience and achieve the results. The word "halftime" has great associations with sports, where an interval or a break is given during a match. Terms in the film within a monologue such as "we're down at halftime", "it's time for a comeback", and "every move counts" were used to convey a sense of urgency without evoking despair or a feeling of guilt. The key messaging technique which was used was a metaphorical effect. Comparing the achievement of the SDGs to a match reinforced the idea of teamwork and hard, strenuous work which is present in professional sports. Positive urgency is also noticeable in the campaign. The campaign was framed in a positive light that there is still home for achieving the 2030 agenda. On the official webpage of the campaign phrases such as "join the team" can be noticed. The Halftime campaign encourages action with a pleasant undertone.

- *Media and platforms*

The Halftime Campaign used a hybrid platform incorporation of both digital platforms and offline tools. Starting with real-life events, during the UN General Assembly the film "Halftime" premiered. The film was played at a variety of

events such as the Global Citizen Festival in Central Park, the Reuters Impact Summit, the SDG Pavilion at the United Nations Headquarters. These are very prestigious and high-ranking places, which made the film quite recognisable. Furthermore, the 2023 SDG Summit in New York physical installations and events branded with Halftime messaging reinforced visibility among policymakers and media outlets. The Halftime campaign actively engaged schools and educators through structured lesson plans and interactive activities. A key resource was the “Halftime Talk for the Global Goals” lesson plan, designed to help students reflect on the progress of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Educators were encouraged to do activities with the students by imagining what the world would look like if the global goals would be achieved to the fullest by 2030. Therefore, on a national scale schools supported the Halftime campaign. Moreover, local organizations hosted SDG-themed workshops, discussion forums and awareness days in community centres or public spaces with an aim of promoting the sustainable development programme as pointed out by World's Largest Lesson organisation (2023). The campaign provided open-access downloadable toolkits for communities, schools, and individuals to create their own Halftime actions. Rather than employing a top-down approach, each individual could decide what “Halftime” means for them. Actions were framed not as centrally run events, but as community-led initiatives using global branding such as “Halftime Talks”.

Touching the subject of digital platforms, particularly television. The United Nations has used donated money to pay for the advertisements on channels such as Sky Sports and NBC Sports during halftimes of major sports events. This was quite symbolic since it correlated with the sport theme of the campaign and the “halftime” of the global goals agenda. On social media, influencers were sharing the message of the halftime campaign. Prominent figures such as Coldplay, Alesha Dixon, Forest Whitaker, Kate Hudson, David Beckham, Comic Relief, Jennifer Garner, Matthew Modine, U2, Alastair Campbell, Nikolaj

Osterwalder. Hashtags like #Halftime, #ForPeopleForPlanet, and #GlobalGoals were promoted across platforms. The social media strategy also included short motivational videos and videos of the mentioned celebrities what "halftime" specifically means for their country. The campaign's webpage includes the actual video of the film as well as text which call for action. It calls to donate money for achieving the SDG goals, sharing the film and joining the halftime campaign. According to Project Everyone (2025) the campaign had about two thousand units of editorial coverage which was broadcasted on national media across the whole globe. Media platforms and TV channels broadcasted the message of the Halftime campaign. National media from Europe, the United States and the UK participated. Platforms such as BBC, Reuters and many others have taken part in broadcasting the campaign. The campaign explicitly invited user-generated content through hashtags like #Halftime, #Act4SDGs to share their interpretation of the "halftime".

- *Analysis of Strategic Features*

Analysing the strategic features of the Halftime campaign is a mature campaign in the UN's communication strategy. It emphasises urgency and renewed collective action which is highly needed for achieving the sustainable development goals. The campaign borrows language from sport, resonating with emotions and an accessible metaphor. The campaign uses a simple and primitive narrative which is understandable to both regular audiences as well as policymakers. Another strategically noticeable trait is the accountability and use of numbers, percentage in the campaign. Halftime placed significant weight on measuring progress, highlighting missed targets, and urging governments, institutions, and individuals to accelerate their efforts. The campaign also used a hybrid model of communication, employing social media and localised events. Despite the fact that the campaign was universal, local activities were still present such as celebrities discussing the "halftime" progress on a national scale of their country. It can be said that during this campaign the United Nations used

“glocalization”. The United Nations was thinking globally while at the same time acting locally. This ensured that the campaign’s message was both unified and context-sensitive. The campaign was very active online and on digital platforms, which is a common trait for the year of 2023. Overall, the Halftime Campaign gave a “a breath of fresh air” to the public discourse around the SDGs and also redefined the narrative, moving from what needs to be achieved, to what has been done and what must urgently happen before 2030 to achieve the SDGs programme. Also, there is a noticeable in participatory approach. It encouraged local communities, schools, and youth groups to organize their own events and actions under a shared global framework. The campaign prioritised a bottom-up approach.

3.5 Comparative analysis

The following section will provide a comparative analysis of the three case studies mentioned above: Tell Everyone (2015), Choose Life (2020), and Halftime (2023). The comparison of these campaigns will allow us to trace how the features of the United Nations communication strategy have evolved from 2015 to 2024. Each of the three campaigns reflects a distinct approach to messaging, audience targeting, media use, and strategic purpose. To begin the comparative analysis, it is firstly vital to describe the characteristics of all the three campaigns. The UN Tell Everyone campaign was one of the first communication campaigns and focused on mass awareness and building knowledge. The target audience was the whole population. The Choose Life campaign developed in a national context. It shows a more targeted and culturally adapted strategy. Finally, the Halftime campaign represents both global accountability and localised approach.

Below is the table summarising the three campaigns:

Table 9

(Table 9 showing comparison between three campaigns)

Feature	**Tell Everyone (2015)**	**Choose Life (2020)**	**Halftime (2023)**
Main Objective	Raise global awareness of SDGs	Inspire behavioural change related to climate action and health	Reignite commitment and motivation at SDG midpoint
Framing and tone	Optimism, universality, shared responsibility	Urgency, moral appeal, personal responsibility	Accountability, comeback narrative, urgency
Audience	Global general public	UK-based citizens, especially millennials and Gen X	Global leaders, institutions, global general public
Geographic Scope	Global	National (UK)	Global, with bottom-up implementation
Media Channels	Global broadcast (TV), online video platforms, social media, campaign website,	TV ads, YouTube, digital storytelling, national press coverage	Digital-first platforms, live global events, social media, SDG Pavilion, school and youth events,

	educational toolkits / guides		community activations

Over the course of these three campaigns spanning from 2015 to 2024 there can be a noticeable pattern of approach. UN's communication strategy evolving from a more top-down approach to more participatory actions. The Tell Everyone campaign set the tone for all the other campaigns by being part of the first UN SDG campaign, however a top-down approach can be noticed by integration of Ministries of Education into the campaign. Higher level institutions were an important part of the Tell Everyone campaign. The Tell Everyone campaign was also quite global, however still localised in specific areas as for example songs written by African singers in support of the Tell Everyone Campaign, however the accent was still on universality. In contrast, the Choose Life campaign has narrowed down its scope and selected a more national scale campaign. Though less globally visible, it reflected growing awareness within the UN of the need to adapt messages to local contexts and media consumption patterns. When analysing the Halftime campaign, it can be said that it was a mixture of both earlier campaigns. It blends elements of both earlier campaigns: the broad outreach and symbolic framing of Tell Everyone, with the digital integration and behavioural targeting of Choose Life.

Talking about localisation, the Halftime launched in 2023 shows the high local patterns. Tell Everyone was also localised but through top-down approaches such as through Ministries of Education, Choose Life was too narrow and solely limited in the scope of the United Kingdom. Halftime enabled a bottom-up participation model that invited schools, youth groups, and community organizations to lead their own SDG-related actions and improve progress towards achieving the 2030 agenda. All campaigns demonstrated localisation of the agenda.

Discussing the digitalisation pattern of the three campaigns, it is noticeable that all of them employed some sort of digital and online patterns. The Tell Everyone campaign employed social media platforms such as YouTube to increase their visibility in an online environment. There was no branded app under the name of the Tell Everyone campaign. However, GlobalGoals.org served as the main content hub, hosting videos, graphics, and goal explanations. The campaign still heavily relies on traditional sources of media such as radio or mobile operators. There was limited reach from the audience due to a limitation of the number of social media platforms used. Moving to the Choose Life Campaign, it also employed social media platforms such as YouTube. The following campaign was hosted on UN Climate Change and UK government partner sites. The Halftime campaign employed a variety of social media platforms, outside of YouTube. The campaign had a specific web page calling to action. Moreover, they offered downloadable resources and engagement guides. Still, user participation was limited due to a seclusion towards only one social media platform. Lastly, the Halftime campaign exemplifies full digital integration: it leveraged TikTok, Instagram[24], downloadable toolkits, and user-generated content campaigns to promote local actions and global momentum. Among the three Halftime employed the most digital tools and realised the digital potential to its fullest.

In addition, all three campaigns had their similarities. They all attempt to simplify and humanize the goals, make use of multimedia platforms, and invite public participation in different forms. All the campaigns also employed both online and offline platforms, however the extent of their use varies across years and campaigns.

To finalise, the trajectory between the 2015 Tell Everyone and Halftime campaign shows growing maturity and sophistication in the UN's communication

[24] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

strategy. The Tell Everyone campaign opened the conversation, Choose Life personalised it, while Halftime challenges institutions and citizens to act with time running out. By examining the following three campaigns it becomes clear that the message evolves from primitive message distribution to strategic engagement. This progression reflects both the changing demands of the global public and the UN's own learning process. As the 2030 agenda slowly moves towards an end the United Nations is no longer about awareness but rather mobilisation and motivation. Moreover, the digitalization and more active use of social media platforms is more evident with time.

3.6 Political recommendations

This section will propose certain political recommendations to the international organisation of the United Nations on how to improve its communication strategy in the SDG field up to the year 2030.

The political recommendations include institutionalizing participatory localization across member states, strengthening accountability communication through national monitoring mechanisms and investing in youth-led and culturally relevant messaging.

- *Institutionalize Participatory Localization Across Member States*

When the Halftime campaign was launched it showed how successfully bottom-up methods can be employed. The UN should encourage Member States to adopt national SDG communication strategies that include frameworks for grassroots participation. Ministries of Education, youth centres and cultural institutions should be encouraged systematically to support the sustainable development programme. SDG messages are advised to be embedded into curricula, local media, and civic spaces, going beyond periodic campaigns. This recommendation suggests moving away from top-down approaches.

- *Strengthen accountability communication through national monitoring mechanisms*

Another communication strategy which would be probably effective is implementation of a mechanism which would track the attainment of sustainable development goals into campaigns. Governments and UN bodies should co-create public-facing progress trackers that reflect local and national SDG achievements and shortfalls. This tool should have a digital footprint as well as easy access and simplicity of language. Even though such an idea already exists, and the UN has SDG trackers, they are not actively communicated. Future campaigns should aim to integrate these tools directly into their messaging, simplify the data presentation, and develop locally adapted dashboards

- *Invest in youth-led and culturally relevant messaging*

Youth and the younger generation are undoubtedly an important target audience of the United Nations. Governments should provide funding and digital infrastructure to support youth-led campaigns, school-based SDG challenges, and localized media content. Moreover, communication and campaigns of the United Nations should also try to adapt language in line with the trend of the youth. While the UN has made notable strides in engaging youth through global campaigns and toolkits, there is a need for stronger political support and funding at the national level.

Conclusion

To conclude, this research sets out to examine the features of the United Nations' communication strategy for sustainable development goals between 2015 and 2024. The topic is highly relevant as effective communication strategies are essential for advancing the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in an increasingly digital and fragmented global landscape. The fact that the United Nations does not state its communication strategy explicitly the following research uncovers its communication approach. When selecting the core IR theory of the study it was decided that liberalism would serve as the foundation. This is because the liberal theory focuses on multiple stakeholders, the free flow of information, transparency, and cooperation among institutions.

The research question posed is "How have the features of the United Nations' communication strategy evolved in the context of the Sustainable Development Goals agenda from 2015 to 2024?". Therefore, to examine the following research question the study was structured into three interconnected chapters. Chapter one has provided historical background and role of communications in SDG field for the United Nations, chapter two has conducted a content analysis of UN reports and social media outputs and finally chapter three has delivered case studies of the three UN campaign, followed by a comparative analysis of the campaigns and afterwards political recommendations were proposed to the United Nations on how to make their communication strategy more effective in the upcoming years of the SDG agenda up to 2030. The overarching aim of the research was to evaluate the hypothesis that 1) The hypothesis is that the UN's communication strategy will go through digitalization as a foundational communication medium to enhance global reach and accessibility. 2) The characteristics of communication strategy will change. Shifting towards global awareness and residing knowledge about newly

introduced SDGs from 2015 to 2017, 2018 to 2021 was described by increasing reach, engagement and support in the period of a global pandemic and from 2022 up to 2024 UN concentrated on localised issues, while maintaining the digital format (hybrid format).

It is significant to look at each chapter and the methodology in detail to understand how each part contributes to evaluating the central hypothesis. Chapter one laid the conceptual foundation by contextualizing the evolution of UN communication practices in light of global development agendas, from the twentieth century, moving to Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) and approaching the SDGs. Strategic intentions behind the communication efforts were examined as well as the different paradigms of development communication were discussed. It was highlighted that active communication is key in attaining the 2030 agenda. Moreover, channels of communication were thoroughly analysed which included more conservative methods as well more modern tools. The chapter highlighted how the launch of the sustainable development goals programme in 2015 coincided with rising digital connectivity and institutional efforts to create a universal, inclusive development narrative. This provided an essential background for evaluating shifts in strategy over time.

Moving to the second chapter which provided a content analysis of official UN SDG progress reports and social media posts on Instagram[25], Twitter, and Facebook[26]. The method of content analysis was chosen since it would vividly reflect the shifts in language patterns overtime and help to identify the evolution of UN's features of communication strategy. One social media post was chosen from each of the three social media platforms on an annual basis through random sampling; as a result, thirty social media posts were analysed from 2015 to 2024. Furthermore, one annual SDG report was taken from 2016 to 2024, making up nine official UN

[25] Instagram (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)
[26]Facebook (owned by Meta, a company recognized as extremist and banned in the Russian Federation)

documents in total. Such a composition of data would provide a both formal outlook on SDG communication as well as a more colloquial approach through social media. Using targeted marker words such as "digital," "local," "global," and "support" in reports, and "partner," "action," "engage," "crisis," and "future" in social media, the research identified linguistic and thematic changes across three periods. The data from the posts was later sorted into three time periods, similar to the hypothesis to test it. As a result, it was investigated that from 2015 to 2017, the focus was primarily on introducing the SDGs and promoting global awareness and universality. Between 2018 and 2021, content emphasized emotional urgency and support, largely shaped by the climate crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. From 2022 onward, the communication showed more explicit use of participatory language with the frequent use of the marker word “support”, disapproved the feature of intensified localisation, since it was present across all time periods. The digitalization which was being traced through the word “digital” was especially apparent after the start of Covid-19.

The third chapter used the method of case study to provide insights from the three United Nations’ campaigns which were Tell Everyone (2015), Choose Life (2020) and Halftime (2023). All three campaigns were purposefully selected from three different time periods. The case studies discovered that the Tell Everyone campaign used a global, top-down broadcast approach with celebrity advocacy and educational outreach with an aim of raising awareness and telling the world about the launch of the SDG programme. Choose Life Was localized to the UK context, using emotional storytelling and cultural familiarity to drive climate action and improve health of citizens in the peak of the Covid-19 pandemic. Halftime integrated global messaging with localized implementation, offering toolkits, school engagement materials, and open-ended participation for communities worldwide stressing the importance of action as the SDG has come to its “halftime”. The comparative analysis proved that there was slow growth of digitalization from the first to the third campaign, Halftime being the most digitised one. In 2015 the

campaign does show awareness building, the 2020 campaign mainly shows urgency and support in times of crises while the 2023 campaign stresses accountability and strategic pivot toward participatory communication models rather than top-down approaches.

The political recommendations that followed emphasized the need to strengthen accountability communication through national monitoring mechanisms, invest in youth-led and culturally relevant messaging and institutionalize participatory localization across member states.

The hypothesis was partially proved. Overall, the findings confirm the increasing role of digitalization in the UN's communication strategy. The results also confirm the hypothesis about the features such as awareness and residing knowledge about newly introduced SDGs from 2015 to 2017, and that 2018 to 2021 was described by increasing reach, engagement and support in the period of a global health crisis. However, results reveal that the shift toward localization was not exclusive to recent years (2022-2024), challenging partially the second part of the hypothesis. The first part of the hypothesis can be approved since both the content analysis and case study show increasing use of digital tools with every year. However, the second part of the hypothesis involving the third time period is partially disapproved and should be altered. The results can be rephrased in such a way: the evolution in communication characteristics—from global awareness (2015 to 2017), to emotional and crisis-oriented, supporting messaging (2018 - 2021), and finally to more inclusive and bottom-up models (2022-2024)—has been evident across content and campaigns. Periods 2015 to 2017 and 2018 to 2021 remained unchanged as in the hypothesis, however the features of the period 2022 to 2024 was altered. The assumption in the hypothesis that localisation appeared only in the recent years should be disapproved. Localisation was present in all of the years in different formats. The 2022 to 2024 period can be framed by increased institutional support for participatory initiatives and bottom-up approach.

Moreover, the research gap was fulfilled by analysing the UN's communication strategy through the scope of social media and bringing insights and novelty into more modern techniques of communication.

Long term perspectives of the future studies is the long-term effectiveness of hybrid communication strategies, as well as future development of digital tools. Future research could also explore how evolving digital platforms like TikTok, Threads, and emerging metaverse environments impact SDG messaging and public engagement.

To finalise, the research clearly outlines the features of the UN communication strategy from 2015 to 2023. It shows its evolving use of digital platforms, adaptive messaging across global and local contexts, and increasing emphasis on inclusive, participatory models.

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